

Harder problems, one volunteer deep.

I mined four years of the Supabase community support forum — every thread, every reply — then read the 96 hardest threads by hand. Two stories: the problems getting harder, and an answer layer that rests on a single volunteer.

41,392

threads analysed

270k

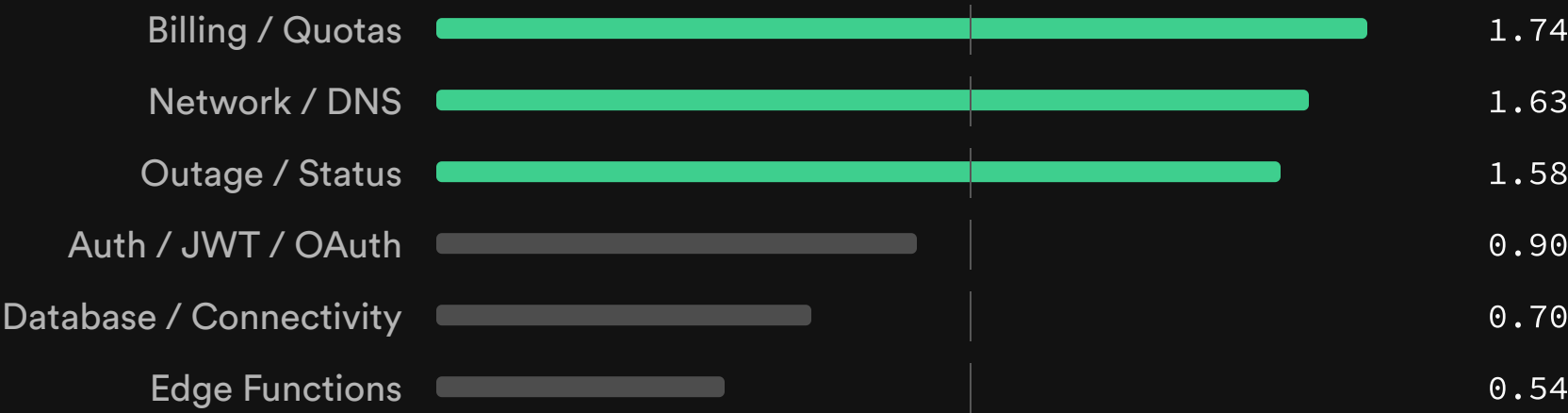
replies read

4 yrs

Aug 2022 – Aug 2026

Three areas grow against an 18% decline

Last 6 months vs the prior 6, per product area, adjusted for the forum-wide decline. 1.0 = moved with the forum. Only three areas rose.



green = growing despite the decline · the rising areas are where the platform itself breaks, not where the docs are thin – Auth, the biggest doc gap, is shrinking

August 2025: moderators started tagging outages

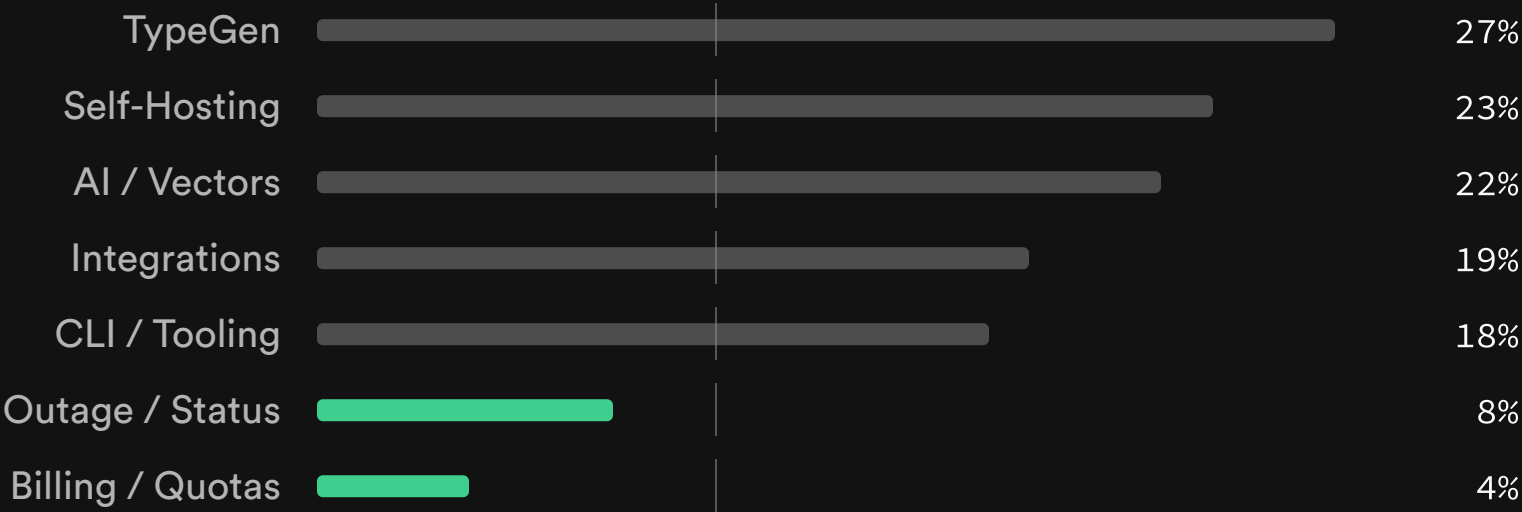
The outage tag (created early 2024, rarely used) suddenly became standard practice in Aug 2025 — 5–25 uses/month, then 58–109/month ever since. Keyword-classified outage volume rose only ~1.3–1.5× over the same window: the step is mostly moderators getting organised, not a reliability cliff.



outage-tag uses per month · the tagging step is real; the underlying volume step is modest · an earlier draft of this chart claimed a reliability regime change – an independent fact-check caught it

Silence is rare — but not evenly

Only 11.6% of 41,392 threads get zero replies, and the last full quarter is 2.5%. Coverage keeps improving as volume falls — but it rests on volunteers, and the specialist corners are still 2–3× the average.



share of threads with zero replies, by product area • line = forum average (11.6%) • answerability tracks how generalist the topic is – the incident areas get answers fastest, the specialist corners wait longest

One volunteer wrote **27%** of all 270,020 answers

Steady at 24–28% every quarter for two years. The top 12 repliers hold ~41% — and **none identify as Supabase staff**. The two biggest answerers describe themselves as volunteer moderators. The capacity was never diversified.

27.0%

of all replies from one community volunteer

~41%

from the top 12 repliers combined

54%

of threads come from 17% of users — a chronic-friction cohort

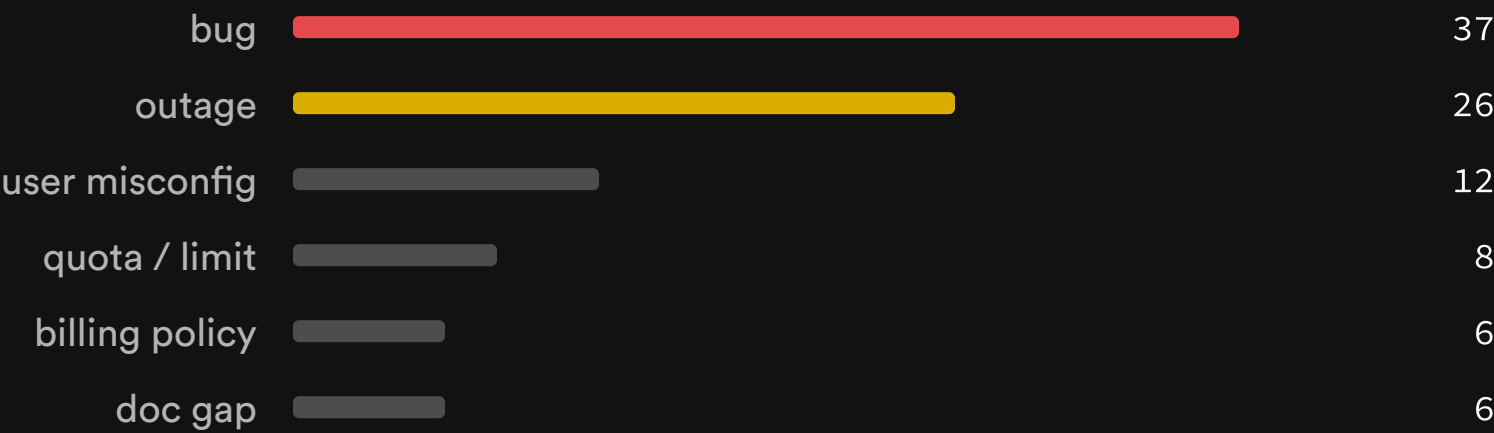
110

threads from the single most frequent poster

when half the forum gets silence and the answered half leans on one person, **response capacity is a single point of failure**

66% bugs or outages. 21% resolved.

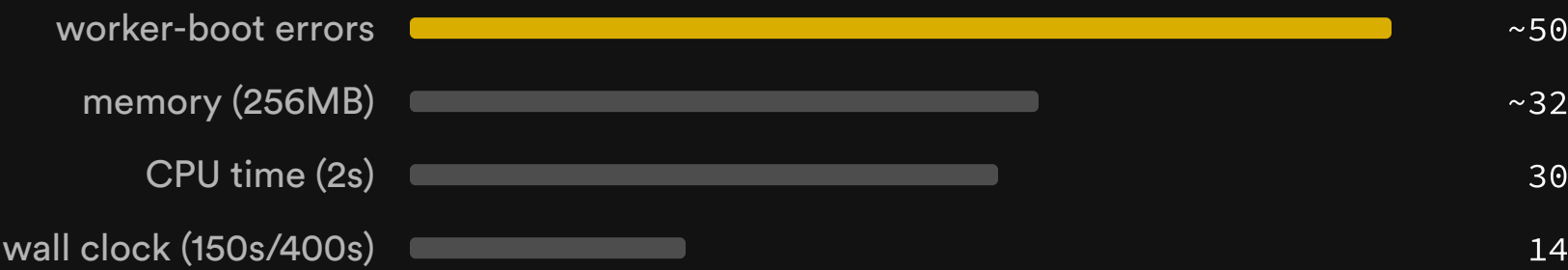
Six independent passes read the 96 hardest threads across the rising areas. Root causes:



the 21% that resolve are almost all `self-fixing user misconfig` · bug and outage threads are never reply-resolved – the only path is a support ticket and days of waiting · saying your plan helps: "pro plan" threads rise 2× and get answered at 2× the forum rate

Edge Functions: limits are found by crashing

There is no 10-second limit (that's Vercel's Hobby tier — zero threads report hitting one). What 2,000 Edge Functions threads actually hit:



no self-serve memory knob, no per-invocation memory in logs, worker-boot failures with no actionable error · the Deno/esm.sh import pain has quietly collapsed (~37 → ~2 threads/quarter) · what persists: local deploy / CLI friction (~31/quarter)

Where the leverage is

- 1

Self-service recovery for stuck lifecycle ops

— force-restart / cancel / rollback + hard timeouts. Resolves the top root cause across all six triage passes.
- 2

Support SLA + auto-escalation for prod-down paid plans

— kills the "magic keyword" ticket hack.
- 3

Honest per-region / per-project status page

— no more "All Systems Operational" while databases are down.
- 4

Forum answer capacity

— staff rotation or AI first-response after 24h of silence. Coverage is good, but one volunteer carries 27% of it.
- 5

Degraded-mode dashboard

— the control plane fails exactly when the project is sick.
- 6

Edge Functions memory playbook + per-invocation memory in logs.

Full interactive report with method, per-area tables, and the reproducible pipeline — link in the post.